

CourtrightCollective

CLAIM IT BEFORE SOMEONE ELSE DOES

COURTRIGHT COLLECTIVE

Grab Your Name *Everywhere*

One afternoon to claim your business name on every platform that matters, in the right order, before somebody else does.

40+ PLACES

ONE AFTERNOON

RIGHT ORDER

COURTRIGHTCO.COM

BUILT IN NASHVILLE

Grab Your Name Everywhere

Why the order matters

Most people do this backwards. They set up Instagram first, get attached to the handle, then discover the `.com` is taken and now their website and their social accounts do not match. Forever.

So we are going to do it in the order that protects you:

1. **Check everything first, claim nothing.** Ten minutes with a notepad
2. **Domain first.** It is the only one you truly own
3. **Google Business Profile second.** It is the one that brings in actual customers
4. **Social handles third.** Even the ones you will never post on
5. **Everything else fourth.** Directories, review sites, the long tail

One rule before we start: pick one handle format and use it literally everywhere. `@bellstreetbakery` on every platform. Not `@bellstreet_bakery` here and `@thebellstreetbakery` there. When somebody remembers your name, they should be able to find you by typing it, without guessing punctuation.

Step 0: Check before you claim (10 minutes)

Open a notepad. Write your name at the top and try these, in this order:

- [] **The `.com`.** Any registrar's search box. Also check `.co` and your industry's common alternative
- [] **A plain search.** Is there a bigger business with this name? A band? Something unfortunate?
- [] **Say the initials out loud.** Businesses have shipped worse acronyms than you would believe
- [] **Instagram,** just by visiting `instagram.com/yourname`
- [] **Facebook,** `facebook.com/yourname`
- [] **The USPTO trademark search.** Free, at `uspto.gov`. You are looking for an existing registered mark in your industry, not doing a legal clearance
- [] **Your state's business name registry.** Usually the Secretary of State site

If the `.com` is taken but the business behind it is in a completely different industry and a different state, you can usually proceed with a variant. If somebody in your industry has it, pick a different name now, while changing costs you nothing.

Good variants, in order of preference:

1. `getname.com` , `namehq.com` , `name.co`
2. `nameservice.com` (`bellstreetbaking.com`)
3. `namecity.com` (`bellstreetnashville.com`)

Bad variants, avoid all of these: hyphens (nobody says "dash" out loud), numbers, deliberate misspellings, and `.biz`.

Step 1: The domain (20 minutes)

The only asset in this whole list you actually own. Everything else is borrowed from a company that could change its rules on a Tuesday.

- ☐ **Register the `.com`**. Expect roughly \$10 to \$15 a year. Anything much higher means it is a premium listing
- ☐ **Turn on WHOIS privacy**. Free at most registrars now. Without it, your home address may be publicly attached to the domain
- ☐ **Turn on auto-renew**. Expired domains get bought within hours by people who resell them back to you
- ☐ **Set a calendar reminder** two weeks before renewal anyway, in case the card on file expires
- ☐ **Turn on registrar lock** so nobody can transfer it out
- ☐ **Register the obvious defensive variants** if they are cheap: the `.net`, the common misspelling, the plural. Point them at the main one
- ☐ **Write down where it is registered** and put the login in your password manager. People genuinely lose track of this

Registrars that do not play games: Cloudflare Registrar (at-cost pricing, no upsells), Porkbun, Namecheap. Avoid anything that advertises a \$0.99 first year, because year two is where they get you.

Step 2: Email on your domain (20 minutes)

A `gmail.com` address on a business card is the fastest way to look like a hobby. This is the cheapest credibility upgrade available to you.

- ☐ Set up email on your domain: Google Workspace or Microsoft 365, both around \$6 to \$7 a month
 - ☐ Create `hello@` or `yourname@`. Skip `info@`, which nobody trusts and everybody spams
 - ☐ Set up forwarding from the addresses people will guess anyway
 - ☐ **Set up SPF, DKIM, and DMARC records**. Your provider gives you the exact values to paste into DNS. Skip this and your email lands in spam, which is a problem you will not know you have
 - ☐ Send a test email to a Gmail address and to an Outlook address. Check the spam folder in both
 - ☐ Update your signature. The Email Signature Pack does this in five minutes
-

Step 3: Google Business Profile (30 minutes, do not skip)

If you serve local customers, this is more valuable than every social account combined. It is what shows up in Maps, in the local pack, and on the right side of a search for your name. It is free.

- ☐ Claim or create your profile at business.google.com

- ☐ Verify it. Usually by postcard, phone, or video. The postcard takes up to two weeks, so start it today
- ☐ Business name, exactly as it appears everywhere else. **Do not stuff keywords into it**, that is against policy and gets profiles suspended
- ☐ Primary category, chosen carefully. It affects what you rank for more than anything else on the profile
- ☐ Secondary categories, only genuinely relevant ones
- ☐ Address, or service area if you go to customers
- ☐ Phone number, the one somebody actually answers
- ☐ Website link
- ☐ Hours, including holiday hours
- ☐ Description, 750 characters. Say what you do and who for. No keyword stuffing
- ☐ Photos: logo, cover, at least five real ones. Real photos beat stock every time here
- ☐ Services or products list
- ☐ Attributes that apply: family owned, veteran owned, wheelchair accessible, whatever is true
- ☐ Turn messaging on, but only if you will actually answer it
- ☐ Grab your review link and save it. The Google Review Booster Kit picks up right here

Bing Places takes about five minutes and can import everything from Google. Small traffic, but it is five minutes.

Step 4: Social handles (45 minutes)

Claim them all, even the ones you will never use. A dormant account you own is infinitely better than an active account somebody else owns with your name on it.

▪ Claim these

- ☐ Instagram
- ☐ Facebook Page (not a personal profile, a Page)
- ☐ TikTok
- ☐ YouTube (set the custom handle)
- ☐ X
- ☐ LinkedIn Company Page
- ☐ Pinterest, if you are visual or sell anything
- ☐ Threads
- ☐ Nextdoor, if you serve a neighborhood
- ☐ Reddit, just the username

▪ For each one, do this much

- ☐ Same handle, exactly
- ☐ Same profile photo, same crop
- ☐ Bio filled in, even on the ones you will not use
- ☐ Website link

- ☐ Two-factor authentication on. This is not optional, handle theft is real and support is slow
- ☐ Recovery email set to your new domain email, not a personal one
- ☐ Logged in from a real device once, so the account does not look abandoned to the platform

On the dormant ones, post once saying where to actually find you. Then let it sit. It costs nothing and it stops somebody else from becoming you.

Step 5: The places customers actually look (30 minutes)

Which of these matter depends entirely on your industry. Do the ones that apply and skip the rest without guilt.

▪ Everyone

- ☐ Apple Business Connect (this is what feeds Apple Maps, and almost nobody claims it)
- ☐ Bing Places
- ☐ Yelp, claim it whether you like Yelp or not, because a listing exists either way and you want to control it

▪ Home services and trades

- ☐ Angi
- ☐ Thumbtack
- ☐ HomeAdvisor
- ☐ BBB, if that carries weight with your customers
- ☐ Your local chamber of commerce

▪ Food and hospitality

- ☐ TripAdvisor
- ☐ OpenTable or Resy, if you take reservations
- ☐ DoorDash, Uber Eats, Grubhub, if you deliver
- ☐ Your city's local food publication or blog

▪ Professional services

- ☐ Your industry's association directory
- ☐ Avvo (legal), Healthgrades (medical), and equivalents
- ☐ Clutch or G2, if you sell to businesses

▪ Retail and product

- ☐ Google Merchant Center
- ☐ Facebook and Instagram Shops
- ☐ Etsy, if it fits

▪ **Consistency is the whole point**

Every listing needs the **exact same** name, address, and phone number. Not "St." here and "Street" there. Search engines use that consistency to decide you are one real business rather than three sketchy ones, and it genuinely affects how you rank locally.

Write your NAP once and copy-paste it every time:

```
Business name:  
Street address:  
City, State ZIP:  
Phone:  
Website:
```

Step 6: Lock it down (20 minutes)

You just created twenty accounts. Now make sure you keep them.

- [] **Password manager**, every account in it. Not a notes file, not your browser, an actual password manager
- [] **Two-factor on everything**, especially the domain registrar and the email account. Those two are the master keys
- [] **Recovery email** on all accounts set to your domain email
- [] **Recovery phone** set to a number you will keep
- [] **Backup codes** for anything that offers them, saved in the password manager
- [] **A second admin** on Google Business Profile and your Facebook Page, someone you trust. Sole-admin accounts are one lost phone from a disaster
- [] **Write down where everything lives**. Registrar, email host, website host, DNS. Future you, or whoever helps you next, will be grateful

The most common small business catastrophe in this whole area: the domain expires because the card on file expired, and by the time anybody notices, the site and the email are both down. Auto-renew plus a calendar reminder prevents it entirely and takes two minutes.

Step 7: Trademark, the honest version (10 minutes to understand)

You do not need a registered trademark to run a business. In the US you get some common-law rights just by using a name in commerce.

Consider registering if:

- You are building something you intend to grow well beyond one location
- You sell products under the name
- You are investing serious money in the name
- You have already had somebody use something confusingly similar

How it actually works: filing at uspto.gov runs a few hundred dollars per class in government fees, plus an attorney if you use one, and the process takes most of a year. A trademark attorney for a straightforward filing is usually a four-figure engagement.

What to do today, at minimum: run the free search at uspto.gov and make sure you are not about to build on top of somebody's registered mark in your industry. That search is free and it takes ten minutes.

This is not legal advice. If the name is central to your business, an hour with a trademark attorney is money extremely well spent.

The whole afternoon, in order

STEP	TIME	WHAT YOU GET
0. Check everything	10 min	Confidence you are not building on sand
1. Domain	20 min	The one asset you own
2. Email	20 min	Instant credibility
3. Google Business Profile	30 min	The thing that actually brings customers
4. Social handles	45 min	Nobody else can be you
5. Directories	30 min	Found where people look
6. Lock it down	20 min	You keep all of it
7. Trademark check	10 min	No nasty surprises later

About three hours. One afternoon, once, and then it is done for years.

Use `Name-Claim-Checklist.csv` to track it, because you will not finish in one sitting and you will absolutely forget which platform you were on.

courtrightco.com

General guidance, not legal advice. Trademark and business registration rules vary by state and country. For anything with real money attached to it, talk to an attorney licensed where you operate.